

Love in the Time of COVID

I. The park

Big trees, freshly cut grass, and the park bench. She knew she was teetering on the edge of something bad- the ground was too unsteady, and she began to sweat as the path under her feet threatened to stretch. If she wasn't careful, she knew her beating heart would find itself crawling up her throat and flinging itself from her mouth. She would grasp it towards her chest, shaky hands desperately clinging to the slippery flesh, until it wriggled it's way out of her hands and into the dirt. That, or she would throw up. She didn't want to do that in front of all these people, so she told herself to pay attention. *What are five things you can see?* An anonymous voice, filling in for a Reddit comment she read at 4 am, played in her head, crackling like it was being played over a phonograph. Maybe it was her algebra teacher- crackling over their 6th period Zoom room. No, it was too feminine, perhaps a teenage girl, or a warm, caring grandfather, gently holding a crying toddler while he mumbled into her hair. Inside her mind, the dial of the radio turned, back and forth, bypassing the static to reach the voices of this disparate cast of characters. She should have been moving on to the next question- *what are four things you can touch*- but she had finished her turn around the circular path. Besides, she realized she hadn't actually named five things she could see yet, so she started again.

Sloping trees curving towards the sidewalk, patches of dirt between the grass, a girl sitting on the park bench. She would try this trick at home, fixing her eyes on some

photo, sock, or textbook, but something would ricochet back off of it, pinging off the walls like a pinball machine. As it flung itself back, it would catch her in the side and drag her into some flicker of a memory or thought. Her eyes would flit around the room, searching for the item that would allow her to stay in one place, and she inevitably became inundated with the thoughts continuing to pelt her. But here her head was silent. Nothing seemed to ricochet off this park, the one she rediscovered a mile away from her house after grabbing her mask and slamming the back door on the tense voices behind her. Nearly every day, she found herself circling the lake with the runners and the families.

Roots from the trees inching under the dirt, clovers speckled between the grass, the big brown eyes of the girl sitting on the park bench. Those eyes were big, absolutely drinking up whatever lay beneath them. The girl was reading her book, mindlessly rubbing the page between her forefinger and her thumb as if they were waiting for her eyes to catch up with them. A strand of dark black hair fell in front of her mask, the rest cascaded down her shoulders and back like water. She was right at home in front of the lake- maybe she read here often? It suddenly struck her that the girl had looked up- *don't stare don't stare don't stare...*

A storm of yellow and red falling onto the roots of the trees, a pacifier some kid had lost between the grass and the clovers, and the beautiful, big brown eyes of the girl on the park bench. She chanced a quick glance to the side as she passed the girl again, and saw the book had a green cover and a green dress. *The Seven Husbands-*

my favorite book. The fabric of the dress seeped off the cover and wafted into the air, floating towards her. What part was the girl on the bench at? Had the protagonists even met? Did she know she loved her yet? She was rounding the corner again, and the refrain picked back up in her mind to not look- she didn't want to play the creep. Yet she couldn't help but look and see-

A park bench... no girl. She glanced around, telling herself she wasn't looking. Why did she feel like she had missed a chance? It wasn't like she was going to *actually* approach the girl. Besides, the sun was setting, and she knew how much trouble she would be in if she got home after it set, so she left.

II. The Presentaton

@hungry2526: "did ur module 14 homework download? mine didn't"

Her heart flickered when she saw her screen light up with the Instagram notification. She hadn't started the module 7 lecture, let alone the homework, and didn't want to admit that to the girl. She raced to open her computer and start clicking through the files, when her phone lit up again.

@hungry2526: "oh my baaaa it's just a slow download. thanks anyways :)"

Damn it. She hadn't even found the homework module yet, but she reached for her phone anyways- as she knew the girl would be off her phone soon and didn't want to wait hours for a response. She logged into her account on Instagram, @floppy_ice, and quickly typed out a response:

@floppy_ice: "wait yeah sorry just saw this! Mine took soooo long to download too I guess it was just a large file or smth! Glad it worked!!"

@hungry2526: "Oh yeah you're probably right, I thought it was just my wifi. Glad you got it too!"

By now, she had pulled it up. It was a very small file, just a one-page PDF and it downloaded without a hitch. Oops. She didn't want the conversation to end, but she didn't know what else to say.

@floppy_ice: "hey actually what did you get for"... delete delete delete... "For problem number 6, did you say".... delete delete delete...

It always threw her off when @hungry2526 dm'd her. There were so many people in this online pre-health professions planning "course," or whatever it is the city wanted to call it. It was nice, she supposed, that they set this up when most hospitals had stopped shadowing, but she could watch videos of sutures on her own if she really wanted. She could definitely do without the mandatory presentations, where they had to present on a health topic that was important to them. Either way, it nearly stopped her heart when she got the first dm from @hungry2526 and saw her profile picture was exactly the same as the girl from the park. Well, mostly the same. In this photo, she could see her mouth and strong chin. She wasn't smiling in her profile picture; instead, her lips were slightly pursed and matching the shock of her raised eyebrows. It seemed too much of a coincidence that the girl had dm'd her out of the blue, because she just *happened* to like the presentation she had given in module 7, and just *happened* to have a question about one of the sources she had used on social withdrawal and paralysis. What if the girl had seen her being a weird creepy stalker all those weeks ago at the park? What if this was some stupid joke and the girl's friends were all laughing at her? It was too much to think about, and she realized she had been typing for too long. She had to send something.

@floppy_ice: "also have u started ur module 16 presentation yet?"

@hungry2526: "...wait uhh no haha"

@hungry2526: "do u have a partner? wanna work together"

III. Park Benches

Big trees, freshly cut grass, and two girls sitting on either side of the park bench.

Thankfully, the bench was 6 feet apart. Or close enough, anyways, for them to both sit together. @floppy_ice got straight to business, delegating tasks and pulling up the assignment @hungry2526 could till she was a business, business, business, type of girl, and she respected her for it. She threw out a joke every now and again, mostly to make @floppy_ice pause the rapid typing and glance to her side. She would turn her lip up ever so slightly, and pretend not to find it funny.

It was so much more fun to do this together than alone in their rooms, @floppy_ice remarked as the sun began to set. @hungry2526 agreed. So when they were done, they agreed they would come back to the park to do their work for module 17. By module 18, they had a rhythm: @floppy_ice would chart out the plan and take the lead, and when she would get stuck in the weeds of a problem, @hungry2526 would throw out a casual insight that would fix whatever problem @floppy_ice was chewing over. By module 20, they were doing their normal class homework together as well, and donning scarves and gloves so they could keep up their favorite meeting time. By module 24, @hungry2526 was staying up late constantly, because over time, less and less homework was being completed at the park bench. The girls were too busy playing armchair philosophers, talking about how they would do medicine differently (and better) than the doctor they knew and ruthlessly critiqued, or get too lost giggling over some story about their childhoods. @floppy_ice continued going to bed at her normal time, but only because she had started doing her homework during class. In module 28, one of

her teachers caught her, and she began doing her work during lunch. Then in module 31, @hungry2526 didn't show up.

IV. The Bedroom

@hungry2526 was sinking. Sinking into a warm duvet, limbs dragging her down like the anchors of a ship. It was a lonely island she found herself on, her bed in the middle of her room. The dirty sheets and clothes juxtaposed the perfectly clean bookshelves, desk paraphernalia clean of any dust and perfectly placed- made to fit together like Tetris tiles.

Three days ago, she couldn't sleep, so she reorganized her entire closet (so what if it was 2 am?) color-coded her notes from class, scrubbed every surface of her room- her floors, her windows, her mirrors- finished the books she had open on her shelf, went for a run, then another run. She was chasing something as she ran, even before it, but she wasn't really sure what. Now all she wanted to do was sleep. Yet after four days of being in her bed, her body wouldn't let her sleep anymore. This had happened to her before, but she always had to get up eventually for class or shower, so she wouldn't have to feel shameful over the sideways glances she knew she was getting (though she never could catch anyone in that voyeuristic act). Now, with her camera off, she could wrap herself up in her grimy cocoon and watch the move around her through a hazy blue screen, while she, for once, stayed still.

She got a notification. @floppy_ice: hey wya? She ignored it. They were supposed to be critiquing each other's patient narratives for module number 26. She had been so excited to get @floppy_ice's feedback on her work, but she barely felt anything as she scrolled away.

It was a few more hours, or maybe the next morning, when she got her fingers to cooperate enough to type. She owed her that, at least.

@hungry2526: sorry had to do something with my parents

@floppy_ice: oh... K.

She felt the three thuds of those ellipses in her chest. She wished she could swallow the phone, chase the metallic dryness with her stale water, and put it all away. Her wishes were interrupted when her phone buzzed again.

@floppy_ice: I missed you!

The words sat on her screen, daring her to answer, all while she pulled the blanket over her head until she disappeared.

"Đi xuống lầu!" her mother's voice cut through her thoughts. Come downstairs.

She had to drag herself out of bed like she was pulling her body through quicksand, each step a negotiation with her limbs. At the bottom of the stairs was her mother, holding a plate.

"Ăn," her mother said. Eat.

V. Moving on

@floppy_ice was leaving for college in two weeks. @hungry2526 was happy for her- really. She had never wished more to wrap her arms around her and give her a long, deep hug, hoping her pride would seep past her skin and into @floppy_ice, so she would *truly* know how happy she was at her friend's success. An air fist bump would have to do. @hungry2526 loved to think of that moment and recall her friend's smile when she told her, which was somehow warmer and brighter than the setting sun reflecting out of her deep brown eyes. She had said she couldn't stay long; she had to get back and tell her parents.

@hungry2526's grinned, knowing how much her friend must care about her to share the big news with her instead of going first to her parents. They had the deepest love for each other. She could probably tell them anything, and they would just wrap her in a big hug. They loved each other so much, and yet @floppy_ice had told her first.

Still, her grin would always fade as she remembered what a "new chapter" really meant- there would be no more study days at the park bench. @floppy_ice said that wasn't true, she would be back for breaks and would definitely message her on insta. But @hungry2526 wasn't convinced. What if she forgot about her? She would be taking real biology classes, learning about what real medicine was like, all while making new friends and meeting exciting new girls. @hungry2526, on the other hand, was stuck watching reruns of the lectures from their pre-health prep modules, which had long

since ended. She knew, no matter how much she wanted to deny it, that she was going to be left behind.

Maybe, in a year, @hungry2526 would be beaming the way her friend was. But their paths would still have to diverge, as there was no way they would end up at the same college. She had always wanted to study in California. She had always pictured herself living and starting a career in California, and of course, @floppy_ice just happened to stumble into that picture when she received her acceptance, and she hated to admit it, but that only made the dream that much more enticing. But application fees were high enough, she couldn't fathom how to cover actual tuition and a move across the country. Her parents had nodded and beamed with pride when she announced she intended to go to college- they knew she would be the first one to go, they said, and they would do their best to send her wherever she wanted to go. But she knew as much as her parents wanted that to be true, that they would be straining to support her, straining even harder to keep the strain hidden. She couldn't do that to them, so she would remain where she was. Still stuck, watching @floppy_ice and the world spin on away from her.

Worst of all, she had nobody to tell all this to. Of course, @floppy_ice was the person she wanted to reach out to when she felt queasy about the future, when she had news, when she had a new show she was dying to talk about- anything and everything really. Their message thread was packed with each thought, idea, and memory @hungry2526 had, that she carefully etched into the keyboard as it she was carving

delicate crystal, all so @floppy_ice could hold it to the light and slowly turn it around and around. But this wasn't a feeling she wanted to know, let alone permanently living in those messages and @floppy_ice's memory of her as she explored California. She was probably too busy, anyhow, fussing over her packing list and wracking her brain to figure out what it was she was forgetting to pack.

She wondered if maybe she could tell *her own* parents how she felt, but dismissed that thought almost as soon as it began. They all loved each other, sure, but there was an unexplainable distance. A crack ready to open into a gaping hole under their feet, if she even attempted to cross it. She wanted to tell them how sad she was, how much she was going to miss @floppy_ice. Best case, they would be confused as to why she cared so much about a girl she had never even mentioned. And on that note, why hadn't she mentioned it, they would wonder. No. She simply couldn't say anything. She bet that if their roles were reversed, and that she was the one who was leaving, @floppy_ice could tell her parents how sad she was. How much she was going to miss her. She opened @floppy_ice's instagram page, scrolled to the picture of her family she had posted last thanksgiving.

Thankful! The caption taunted her. She could probably tell them *anything*. They were all posed in front of their house, her dad and mom in the middle, the sisters flanking them, wide smiles on all their faces. All that was missing was the picket fence. They were perfect, she was their star braniac going all the way to California, and she was sure she could come out and say she had murdered someone, and those perfect smiles wouldn't budge.

It wasn't a thought she could entertain, it made her too sad, so she kept scrolling on @floppy_ice's page to push the thought away. Stared at her beautiful pictures with her many friends, masks pulled down for a second to share their blissful happiness with the rest of the world. Eventually, she found herself at @floppy_ice's graduation, and clicked on the tag of her school's instagram page so she could find the video that had become a bit of a solace to her: the valedictorian speech from her graduation.

There she was in the digital flesh- @floppy_ice- though the caption called her by her real name. Hair long over her blue gown, makeup her older sister had insisted on doing for her, looking so official and grown up.

"We've spent the last year learning in isolation," she said, her voice clear and steady, even though @hungry2526 knew she was terrified because she had texted her about it constantly to get advice on her speech. "But I learned that isolation doesn't mean alone. Our high school journey may have looked different- Zoom rooms were our classrooms, our study groups took place over phone calls, and our friendships flourished in socially distanced parks, we did it together. And we will continue forward, forging new paths and relationships, but always knowing that we accomplished this hard thing with each other. And with that, I will stop boring you with this speech so we can get to the catered reception- congratulations to the class of 2020!"

She paid special attention to the part where she mentioned the park benches, every time she watched the video. That wasn't in any of the scripts she had helped edit.

It was a puzzle to chew on, and she loved puzzles. Did she add it on the fly? *Did she add it for her other friends, or....* She barely dared to finish that thought. Besides, judging by the flood of loving and congratulatory comments below, @floppy_ice had likely studied with a lot of people over their study sessions in the park. She remembered the first time she watched the video and wanted to say something about the park bench comment, but didn't want to come off like *that*- and opted for a more neutral congratulations:

@hungry2526: "just watched your speech!"

@floppy_ice: "Oh god that thing is online??"

@hungry2526: "yeah lol but dw it was great"

@floppy_ice: "aww thanks I'm so worried it would turn out badly, genuinely i was so nervous i thought i was gonna pass out"

@hungry2526: "haha I couldn't tell, you looked perfect"

She had stared at that last message in the eternity (or realistically, a second or two) between hitting send and waiting for her friend to light up her screen again.

@floppy_ice: "Thank you"

@floppy_ice: "that means a lot coming from you"

VI. Spring Break

@floppy_ice's foot was tapping out a rapid beat on the grass. She kept trying to stop it, but she had a restless energy that kept bubbling from within her. She fussed with her hair- keep it in front of her shoulders? Behind them? Tie it up? She kept cycling through as she wondered, where was she?

@floppy_ice almost regretted sending @hungry2526 that message last night- "just got off my flight home!! Park bench tomorrow?" She knew things had been odd between them lately, but she didn't expect the response to be a simple "yes," nothing more. She had studied that message as if it was a quote from her intro to lit class, but the meaning branched a thousand directions. She had felt that something was wrong, but couldn't explain what.

She blinked into existence. The thought occurred to her- she had never before seen her lips in person.

"You're here!"

"Yeah, hi!"

There was a moment where everything fell right into place. They talked about California, how it was big and beautiful and so fun to explore but so overwhelming at the same time, about @hungry2526's senior year bio class (it was fine, she insisted, the teacher doesn't know what he's talking about but at least he's funny), @floppy_ice's first

and last frat party, they planned @hungry2526's college class schedule for next year so she could commute for next year... in other words, everything.

@floppy_ice had to log onto a Zoom meeting to plan for a student organization for five minutes, but @hungry2526 didn't mind, she had brought a book. *The 7 husbands*.

"You still haven't finished it?" @floppy_ice asked.

"Oh what no, I finished it forever ago, I just like to reread it."

"OH! Fair enough, it's really good... so who's your favorite *husband*?"

They burst out laughing. They both knew it wasn't really about Evelyn's husbands. It was about the woman she met along the way: Celia, her true love.

"You know what I really like about this book?" @hungry 2526 said, thumbing the pages while she spoke. "Evelyn has all these different soulmates. There's Celia, obviously- the big love story that everyone talks about. But then there's Harry, her manager, who's kind of her best friend soulmate. He's there through everything- every husband, every scandal, every fight with Celia- heck, I think he's there longer than Celia. It's actually really beautiful when you think about it."

@floppy_ice nodded. This was what she loved about @hungry2526. This beauty, this meaning- only she could see things like that.

“You know, I was actually thinking-” @floppy_ice’s voice cut through a little too strongly. @hungry2526’s fingers froze on the page, and she looked up. “I hope you could be that for me. A soulmate. You know, like Harry. The best friend kind.”

@hungry2526 blinked. “The best friend kind?”

“Well yeah... I mean, it’s so much stabler than the relationship kind... and I mean-” she was rambling. Worse, the world started to stretch again. The fear began to set in, but @hungry2526 cut her off-

“No. I get it”

“You get it?”

“Yeah.”

“Yeah! Okay good... so-”

“Actually I forgot I have to get going home before 12 so I can start an assignment.” @hungry 2526 blurted out.

“...Oh! Yeah, okay! Well it was good to see you! Do you want to-”

“Good to see you too.” @hungry2526 stated cleanly, neutrally, but she was already walking away. @floppy_ice watched her as she went, sitting dumbfounded and alone on the park bench.

Analysis

Inspired by themes from *On Earth We're Briefly Gorgeous*, I set out to write a short story exploring a queer love story between two teen girls- both American-born, but one is the child of Vietnamese immigrants (@hungry2526) and one is white (@floppy_ice). In a coming-of-age style story, I want to explore how they navigated falling in love with another girl for the first time, and how factors like COVID, mental illness, and their inability to accept their own queerness coalesce and impact their relationship.

To complicate the already difficult journey of discovering one's sexuality, their story takes place during the height of COVID: @floppy_ice enters college as COVID restrictions are being lifted. Not only are they falling in love and realizing they are queer for the first time, but they are doing so in a world without physical touch and where intense social isolation is necessary. Partially, this lack of touch is meant to show how pure their relationship is. It also functions to make their relationship feel surreal and almost as if it's happening in an alternate universe, which is meant to symbolize the struggle of accepting one's own queerness.

Not only are they incredibly distanced when they are in person, but their love takes place a lot over Instagram messages- this is because they can only steal away to the park so often. Their digital love adds another layer of separation, and to emphasize how digital their relationship and understanding of each other is, I only refer to them as their Instagram handles. Social media also plays a role in worsening @hungry2526's BPD: she is always scrolling and at one point describes the "blue light" of her phone as

a world going by without her, as media makes her feel even more distanced from the world (though she is definitely addicted to her phone).

The digital, socially distanced, and hidden nature of their relationship from the others in their life makes it so it is fundamentally different from a “normal” relationship, and positions their love outside of “normal” society. Consider the chapter titled “The Bedroom,” which is meant to invoke a thought that perhaps this story will follow a more traditional path of two people falling in love, but that a “normal” story was never going to happen, given the circumstances. The many factors that induce distance and make their relationship “different” are meant to symbolize and reinforce the ways queer relationships can feel different and shameful, and how that can take a toll on the relationship. This is expressed literally as they are unable to admit their love for each other (as in the final scene when @floppy_ice talks about wanting to be platonic soulmates), and makes the love feel surreal.

Complicating their experience further, they both also deal with mental illness- @floppy_ice has anxiety, and chapter I describes her on the verge of a panic attack. @hungry2526 has Bipolar Disorder, and Chapter III describes her in a depressive episode. COVID was notoriously bad for worsening mental health. For example, Chapter III alludes to how COVID worsens @hungry2526's depressive episodes by almost enabling her- she's able to just stay in bed instead of having to participate in society, which makes her depression worse.

Moreover, while these characters mirror each other in a lot of ways- both driven, intelligent, want to be doctors, refusing to acknowledge their queerness because it is scary and untrodden territory- I contrast their college experience by referencing their upbringing and the difference between @hungry's 2nd generation Vietnamese immigrant status and lower socioeconomic standing and @floppy_ice's picket fence-esque family. @hungry is a year below @floppy_ice, and symbolically should be thought of as "behind" as well in terms of her ability to go after their shared dream- despite them both having similar merit. @floppy_ice gets to live out @hungry's dream of going to college in California effortlessly- a place and phrase chosen specifically to symbolize the American dream- whereas @hungry's options are more limited. Though her parents want the world for her, she is upset that she is going to an in-state school instead of California as well.

I mirror Little Dog's early assumptions about Trevor's family in this story by having @hungry2526 believe that @floppy_ice could tell her family anything, including the fact that she is queer. However, @floppy_ice doesn't come out, as she doesn't believe she can deviate from the picture-perfect daughter trope I have applied to her. Whether or not either of their families would be accepting is beyond the point- the fact that neither of them came out shows that they don't feel they can be out, which is ultimately what drives these choices.

Returning to the surrealness of their experiences, the focus on the park bench is meant to convey an inescapable circularity of their experiences- they start where they

began. Consider, in chapter I, @floppy_ice returns to the same surroundings over and over again. This is meant to foreshadow how the story will end where it began. While the characters, in a nonexistent next book, would show personal growth from this experience, it was doomed to fail from the beginning because of the many factors that created distance between them- COVID, the resentment at being able to go to college in California, their inability to acknowledge their queerness. The inability to acknowledge their queerness comes to a head in the final scene, though the odd feeling @floppy_ice has is meant to show how the other factors inserting distance between them have been slowly chipping away. At the end, it all comes to a head, and they realize they have to end it- they cannot continue to love each other in this way. Though their first love is messy, I imagine that in these fictional characters' second love stories, they are able to embrace their queerness and craft themselves a happy ending.